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THIRST AIDS FOR STRAYS

From water bowls placed for thirsty stray animals to coconut shell feeders for urban birds, here are two organisations finding simple, sustainable ways to help the city's voiceless residents endure the summer **P4**



ENVIRONMENT GROUP'S CALL TO ADYAR RESIDENTS

A community waste collection initiative seeks to revive the resource value of discarded materials **P3**

Sholinganallur pond made 'fighting fit'



Revived through a restoration exercise, this waterbody is now monsoon-ready, having been redesigned for more efficient rainwater storage



Sathyavani Muthu Pond; and (right) rainwater pits to drain water into the pond. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.S ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Environmentalist Foundation of India (EFI) has restored a pond in Sholinganallur.

Located west of Buckingham Canal, Sathyavani Muthu pond was once brimming with life, serving as

a nesting site for birds and reptiles. However, with rapid urbanisation, the land pattern changed, leading to the collapse of the wetland ecosystem.

EFI founder Arun Krishnamurthy says, "The pond was a severely neglected urban waterbody. Sewage discharge, garbage dumping,

excessive silt deposition and the spread of invasive weeds had reduced this ecologically important space to a degraded state. Despite this, the pond played a crucial role in mitigating floods, supporting groundwater recharge in a dense urban landscape, and sustaining urban biodiversity."

Restoration efforts

EFI volunteers dewatered the pond, removed trash, weeded out invasive weeds and removed the sludge. Following this, in a section of the pond, volunteers have prepared a rainwater storage area, formed bunds, and constructed re-vegetation and boundary walls.

Spread over 3,250 square meters, this important freshwater source supports all lifeforms around it, adds Arun.

Outside the pond, two rainwater drainage pits have been constructed to collect stormwater and drain it into the pond.

To prevent misuse of the pond by antisocial elements, boundary walls have been constructed, and gates and railings installed between and on the walls. A fresh coat of paint has also been applied.

Today, it has been restored as a waterbody, ready to store rainwater in the upcoming monsoons.

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Velachery school kids steer road users **towards safety**

DAV School in Velachery is among institutions that have bagged a gold medal for activities taken under National Road Safety Mission for Schools



LIFFY THOMAS

A road safety rally resonating with slogans is a great way to raise awareness about the issue. And when conducted outside the school gates involving children, the effect can be arresting. DAV School in Velachery has done just that seeking to instil responsible road behaviour among citizens.

The school recently won the National Road Safety Education Excellence Awards 2025-26 in the gold

category, instituted by the National Road Safety Mission for Schools, a nationwide, collaborative, non-government initiative led by Academia Axis Edtech, International Road Federation (IRF) India Chapter and Eduxa.ai.

Uma S, supervisory head, DAV School, says organising a road safety rally around the school was challenging as it involves getting permission from the police and taking a lot of precautionary measures, but people on the road take note as children steer these exercises.

Putting up a message board at the school struck a cord with many visiting the campus. Students made an imprint of the message and displayed it. Messages include insisting that the parent wear a helmet even when the journey covers a short distance.

"We spoke to students to find that many had posted a message calling attention to road safety measure their parents were not taking," says Uma.

Since the school signed up for National Road Safety Mission for



An awareness rally; Uma S. receives the award; and students take the pledge.

Schools in December 2025, they chalked out a series of activities spread across months. The Central Board of Secondary Education had also sent out a circular in January 2026 asking schools to drive programmes as part of Road Safety Month, giving greater impetus to the campaign.

Uma says when taking up such campaigns it is important to involve parents.

"We sent out a circular to parents across classes that the school has signed up for the programme and children are being trained to become road safety ambassadors. Such communication is important

to engage parents, and we had children taking home one message a day," she says.

Traffic rules, pedestrian safety, helmet awareness, seat belt usage, emergency precautions and responsible road behaviour were effectively disseminated through colourful posters, slogan writing competitions, chart presentations, speeches, mime shows, skits, and classroom discussions.

Other highlights include principal Sujatha M administering the Road Safety Oath. Through continuous awareness activities, the school hopes to instil the message on road safety hard.

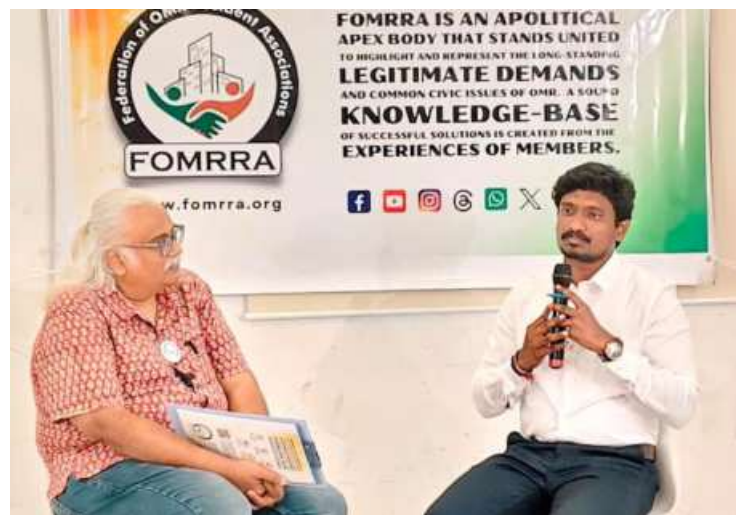
FOMRRA plans periodic reviews of **MLAs' performance**

HARSHA KODA

The 2026 elections marked a historic shift in Chennai's IT corridor, and it can be put down in numbers. A turnout of 55% in 2021 to around 80.4% in 2026.

In addition to the overall mind-set this election and the increased participation of young voters, Federation of OMR Residents Associations' (FOMRRA) digital campaigns and technical advocacy have contributed to the turnout in Sholingnallur and Thiruporur, two constituencies that fall in FOMRRA's engagement space.

FOMRRA's post-election strategy involves engaging victors ECR P. Saravanan and B. Vijayaraj via dedicated WhatsApp groups. The Federation will represent the "OMR Manifesto" to secure commitments on priority projects, ensuring Local Area Development funds are used transparently. Periodic re-



ECR P. Saravanan and B. Vijayaraj, MLA elect from Sholingnallur and Thiruporur assembly constituencies respectively, with Harsha Koda during the pre-poll Meet-the-Candidates sessions conducted by FOMRRA.

views will hold MLAs accountable for water, sewage and road connectivity progress.

FOMRRA's philosophy is simple:

taxes buy services, but voting earns the right to demand accountability.

(Harsha Koda is co-founder of FOMRRA)



During an earlier drive by EcoKconnectors.

Environment group's call to Adyar residents

A community waste collection initiative seeks to revive the resource value of discarded materials

To encourage responsible waste disposal and strengthen community-led sustainability initiatives, EcoKconnectors in partnership with recycling partner SPRECO and residents' welfare associations of R.K. Nagar and Mandaveli Raja Street, is organising "Resource Revival Drive", a community waste collection initiative aimed at reviving the resource value of discarded materials.

The Resource Revival Drive will be held on May 17, 2026 (from 10 a.m. to 4 p.m.) at two collection points in Chennai. One, RK Nagar Collection Point: Opposite Ananya Apartments, 4/6 Tiruveedhiamman Koil Street, Sringeri Mutt Road, Raja Annamalaipuram. And two, Mandaveli Raja Street Collection Point: Outside Dwaraka Apartment, 21/33 Raja Street, Mandaveli, Raja Annamalaipuram.

The exercise resonates with a battle cry: "Together Let's Revive Resources, Recycle Responsibly, and Renew our Earth!"

A press release from EcoKon-

nectors notes that by diverting such items from dumping grounds and extending their lifecycle through recovery and recycling, the initiative seeks to reduce environmental burden. Residents from Mylapore, Mandaveli, Adyar and surrounding neighbourhoods are invited to participate in the drive. The organisers have also positioned the initiative as an opportunity for households to undertake indoor clean-up and decluttering activities during the ongoing summer vacation and heatwave period.

The drive will accept a wide range of dry waste materials including usable clothes, footwear, tailor rags, bedsheets, paired shoes and slippers, metal cans and foil, glass bottles and jars, toys, stationery, chargers, cables, small electronic items, dry-cell batteries, small electrical items, clean packing thermocol, newspapers, books, cartons, plastic bottles, covers and containers, provided they are clean and dry, says the press release.

Organisers have clarified that

mattresses, pillows, broken tube lights, wood and furniture will not be accepted.

Participants have been requested to bring only dry waste materials to the designated collection points and to place items in appropriately labelled bins or cartons. Residents have also been advised not to leave waste outside the collection area or after the designated collection hours.

The press release points out all collected materials will be transported to SPRECO's material recovery facility (MRF) and textile recovery facility (TRF), where they will be processed for reuse and recycling.

The initiative underscores the growing role of citizen participation and neighbourhood-level collaboration in addressing urban waste management challenges.

For further information, residents may contact EcoKconnectors at 7010848668 or 9940056069, and SPRECO at 9150003024 or 9655880250.



Songs from 'Versatile Asha' in Taramani

Satrangi's next presentation 'Versatile Asha' will be held on May 10 from 5:45 p.m. at TEACH Auditorium, Taramani.

This programme will feature memorable songs of the iconic singer Asha Bhonsle from movies like *Mere Saan*, *Don*, *Chhoti Si Baat*, *Jawani Diwani*, *Kismat*, *Umr*, *rao Jaan*, *Ijaazat*, *Yaadon Ki Baaraat*, *Kashmir Ki Kali*, *Hum Dono* and *Waqt*.

The programme will be presented by Promod, Ramya, Smriti and Abhishek on pre recorded tracks.

Tickets for this event are priced at ₹500 and ₹300 and will be home delivered on calling 9884778073.



Xpressions marks 4th anniversary with musical fervour



Xpressions, a fast-growing karaoke collective, celebrated its 4th anniversary with a vibrant musical evening at the Music Academy mini hall recently. The event, hosted by Usha Sampath Kumar, drew an enthusiastic audience of over 150 attendees and unfolded as a memorable four-hour showcase of talent and camaraderie.

The programme featured a repertoire of 28 songs spanning timeless classics and contemporary favourites. The performances struck a chord with the audience, many of

whom joined in with spontaneous applause, foot-tapping, and sing-alongs, lending the evening a warm and participative atmosphere, said a release.

The organisers have hinted at an upcoming musical event in the near future.

With four successful years behind them, Xpressions continues to grow as a cultural space where passion for music finds expression, and the journey ahead appears set for even greater milestones, added the release.

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‘Cool hands’ scarce in Chennai

With the mercury shooting up, calls for AC repair experts abound, and many of them go unanswered. A case for making AC technician courses more attractive to youngsters



LIFFY THOMAS

As summer temperatures spike in Chennai, air-conditioner technicians are working overtime, with households and businesses scrambling to install, repair and service cooling systems.

All major service providers note that they are struggling to meet the spurt in demand.

That wheels in a question: is the market being fed with a steady pool of trained AC technicians?

Sundaresan Ranganathan, director, Tamilnadu Advanced Technical Training Institute (TAT-TI), a registered organisation, says the Tamil Nadu Industrial Training Institute started offering a two-year programme in Mechanical Refrigeration and AC in 1985 but the course was discontinued during the pandemic due to poor intake.

Scaled-down versions of the same programme are being offered now, one with a three-month duration, and the other six months, but both struggle to inject sufficient trained technicians into the talent pool.

Polytechnic colleges and service providers have been adapting to attract and retain students and skilled technicians but they



At Ramakrishna Mission Polytechnic College's lab.

have been facing many obstacles. Ramakrishna Mission Polytechnic College in Mylapore, managed by Ramakrishna Mission Students' Home, runs a free residential diploma programme, affiliated to Directorate of Technical Education. At the end of every semester, the college management offers additional training for their students with its training partners, refrigeration and AC course being one of them.

M. Sugumaran, principal of the College, says students are more drawn towards the automobile and manufacturing sector, followed by product design and as developers in the technology sector.

“Diploma students are not so keen on being a technician, preferring to enter the field in supervisory roles for the three-year programme they studied,” says Sugumaran. He says unlike in the past students there have many other alternative courses that show equal, if not greater promise, so becoming a HVAC technician has lost its charm.

Many such institutions admitted students who completed Class X or Class XII; or even dropouts.

According to a report by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) titled ‘Formalising Air Conditioner Technician Training and Certification in India for Climate-resilient Servicing’, the demand for skilled room air-conditioner technicians will rise to around 2 million by 2036-37.

The servicing sector can play a significant role in helping deal with refrigerant overuse for servicing, and bring operational energy-efficiency closer to the designed benchmarks.

For a ready pool of trained technicians, the curriculum offered at most ITI institutions needs a revision. The report says that content must be co-created with industry participation and updated periodically to respond to changes on account of the refrigerant and technology transitions.

In addition to technical training, focus should also be on imparting entrepreneurial and soft skills such as communication and interpersonal skills. Offering social security to informal AC technicians are among other ways to draw people to the HVAC field.

Role of service providers

From incentives to career opportunities, major service providers are adopting different strategies to retain qualified talent.

Hitachi Engineering Excellence Centre runs training programmes to upskill AC technicians with the latest in the field. Its monthly training programmes conducted at SRM Easwari Engineering College in Ramapuram has employees from its 60-plus franchise partners in Tamil Nadu taking part in it.

Besides a skill development centre that Bluestar operates in Ambattur, it runs a training programme on wheels that goes to the doorsteps of the dealers to train technicians in the latest technologies.

Thirst aids for strays

From water bowls placed for thirsty stray animals to coconut shell feeders designed for urban birds, here are two organisations in Chennai finding simple, sustainable ways to help the city's voiceless residents endure the summer



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

As temperatures rise in Chennai during May, the thirst for kindness rises with it. More than ever, the voiceless residents need acts of human kindness to get through their days. A bowl with water or feed is just what the doctor has ordered for animals and birds that are not pets, and have to fend for themselves through the year; and find regular sources of sustenance dry up during peak summer.

Besant Memorial Animal Dispensary (BMAD) in Besant Nagar is step-

ping up once again with its free community water bowl initiative. In its fourth year, the initiative distributes cement water bowls free of cost to residents, community feeders and animal lovers keen on placing them outside homes and shops and in street corners.

The organisation procures the bowls through donations and sponsors, sourcing them from local nurseries and suppliers before distributing them across the city. This year, BMAD initially procured 150 bowls, all of which were claimed within two days.

“We started this because animals

on the streets simply have nowhere to access water,” says Neeraja Venkateswaran, Head of Operations at BMAD. “Natural waterbodies have disappeared or become inaccessible because of urban development. What happens then is that these animals end up suffering from dehydration, heat strokes, and many of them do not survive something as basic as the unavailability of water.”

Where kindness swells, strangely, challenges abound. The logistics is daunting, observes Neeraja.

“And sometimes people ask for larger numbers, but we have to make sure



Bowls kept ready for distribution at BMAD in Besant Nagar.

everyone gets access fairly. Right now, we are distributing a maximum of one bowl per person. We have now placed another order for 400 more.”

The larger concern lies not in distribution, but maintenance. A neglected water bowl can quickly become unhygienic in Chennai's summer heat.

“People should ensure that the water is changed regularly because stagnant water becomes a breeding ground for mosquito larvae,” Neeraja explains. “And if larger animals like cows or horses come there often, it is better to create a permanent water trough because the cement bowls can break.”

The water bowls can be picked up from the BMAD office from Monday to Saturday between 09:30 a.m. and 12:00 p.m., and again from 02:30 p.m. to 04:00 p.m.

Beyond the bowls themselves, Neeraja believes there are countless small acts that can help animals survive the season. These include offering simple meals such as vegetable broth or chicken broth mixed with leftover rice; creating shaded spaces for animals to rest during peak afternoon heat; if possible, allow community dogs to sit inside gated areas or verandahs for some time during extremely hot afternoons.

For further details, BMAD can be contacted via the official email ID: admin.bmadts@gmail.com. They can also be reached through their official Instagram and Facebook handle: @besantmemorialanimaldispensary.

A coconut bowl crafted for feathered residents



A coconut shell bird feeder workshop was organised by Thuvakkam on May 9 at the NGO's head office in Valasaravakkam, bringing together constituencies across demographic divides. The exercise splices urban bird care and sustainable living.

The workshop introduced participants to the process of converting discarded coconut shells into eco-friendly bird feeders.

“Our main aim is to make sure every terrace has an eco-friendly bird feeder so that birds can also survive during summer,” says Kodama Durga Prasad, executive associate – Programs and Volunteering. He added, “Those who do not have space to hang it on their terrace can make use of the urban forests around the city.”

A DIY project

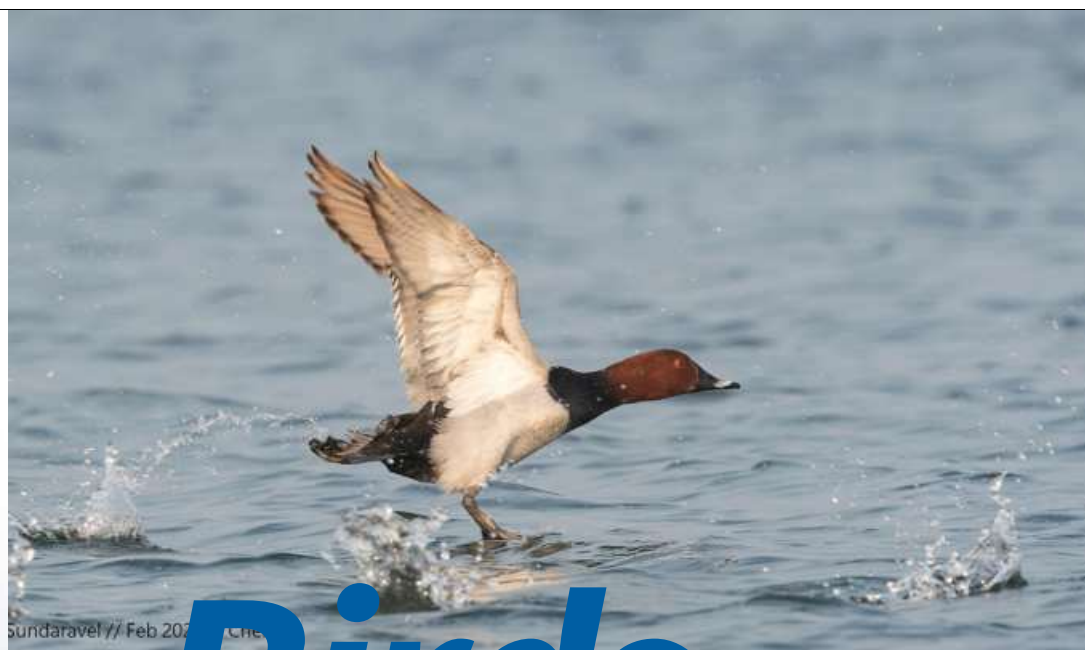
- Take a dry coconut shell and remove all

the inside flesh

- Wash and sun-dry it completely
- Smooth the edges using sandpaper so it is safe for birds
- Make 2-3 small holes near the rim using a drill or heated nail
- Pass jute rope or strong string through the holes and tie secure knots
- Create a loop at the top for hanging
- Optional: Add a small stick across the shell as a perch
- Fill it with millets, rice grains, broken wheat or sunflower seeds
- Avoid salty, spicy or cooked food
- Hang it in a shaded and safe place away from cats
- Refill food regularly and clean the shell once a week to maintain hygiene



During a coconut shell feeder-making session.



Birds read invisible maps

On World Migratory Bird Day, here is a case study of the Common pochard, exploring possible reasons why this bird could be 'warming up to' birders in the Chennai Metropolitan Area but giving those in Madurai the cold shoulder

PRINCE FREDERICK

"Not even time for birds to fly to southern skies." That is a line from Stevie Wonder's "I Just Called To Say I Love You", a song that has stood the shifting fads of time. And that line refers to an avian pattern that has persisted through time. It hints at birds migrating from the north, escaping its inclement winter to sojourn in the south. While the escape will continue winter after winter, the sojourn can undergo changes of address, depending on local factors, anthropogenic and climatic.

Welcome to the choices made by migratory birds: the how and

Common pochards at Amoor Lake near Chennai in February 2026.
PHOTOS: SUNDARAVEL PALANIVEL

why of it.

Dr. T. Badri Narayanan is an ophthalmologist with an eye for birds, an eye sharpened with some degree of formal training (a correspondence course from Bombay Natural History Society and an ornithology course offered by NPTEL during the pandemic) but largely on account of time spent on the field. He illustrates the possible causes of change in bird migration with his observations of the Common pochard in the Chennai Metropolitan Area and his regular stomping ground, Madurai.

Dr. Narayanan notes that the migratory Common pochard is sighted sporadically in the Chennai Metropolitan Area which includes patches of Kancheepuram and Chengalpet. It is also documented from time to time in other parts of southern Tamil Nadu. He recalls sightings of Common pochard flocks around 15 years ago at Aarpakkam tank near Kancheepuram as well as Ponnur lake, also set in the same geography. During the 2025-26 migratory season, the Common pochard showed up as a flock at Amoor lake, near Sirudhavar in Chengalpet district, not too far from Chennai.

In contrast, birders in Madurai are being stood up by this bird.

For anyone who has birded in the 1980s and 90s, this could be startling as Madurai was a sure-fire destination in this bird's winter itinerary. Dr. Badri Narayanan notes that a species can change its wintering address if it is up against habitat degradation. The reality in Madurai does not point in that direction, at least not on the surface, and he looks elsewhere for a possible cause.

He observes that globally, the Common pochard's numbers are dwindling and the species has moved from "Least Concern" to "Near Threatened", and therefore, fewer birds migrate deep into peninsular India. The suggestion is that they could be happily "hot-desked" with enough "seats" provided for them in the wetlands of central and northern India.

A migratory bird might change its wintering address for one or a combination of these reasons. One, habitat destruction. Two, food scarcity. Three, climatic changes. Four, population decline reducing migratory spread (the Common pochard's situation in Madurai probably checks this box). Five, availability of suitable habitats earlier on in their migratory route. Dr. Badri Narayanan notes that a cause can be identified only with sufficient data gathered over a long period of time with observations, around 10 years or more. He points out that citizen-science platforms such as eBird can be source for that kind of data.



NPSI demonstrates strong performance in examinations



Abhik Biswas and Adhika Shrila Ramesh.

Students of NPS International recorded a good performance in the ICSE (Class X) and ISC (Class XII) examinations for the academic year 2025-26.

In the ISC examinations, the school recorded an overall average of 91.36 percent, says a press release issued by the institution.

Adhika Shrila Ramesh emerged as the school topper with 98.25 percent, followed by Advika Satish Pillai with 98 percent and Mridula Kashiram with 97.25 percent.



The class X examination results were equally noteworthy, achieving an average of 90.97 percent.

Abhik Biswas topped with 99.4 percent, followed by B. Sriresh and Purna Suresh with 98.2 percent. R. Kriya, Vidya Harini Poovanthan, and Sivadarshini Shenbagaram secured 97.6 percent. The results reflect consistent effort by students and faculty, alongside the school's sustained focus on holistic, rigorous learning, according to the press release.

French salon brand opens store in Thoraipakkam

Marie Claire Paris, the French brand of the Salon and Nails chain, recently inaugurated its store on Rajiv Gandhi Salai in Thoraipakkam.

Jayathilal Challani, chairman of the Challani Group of Companies, was the chief guest.

Marie Claire Paris has salons in Bangalore, Hyderabad, Lucknow, Chennai, and Warangal.

The unisex salon offers a full range of hair, skin, beauty, and nail services.

The store is located at Grace Towers, above Challani Jewellery, adjacent to KFC Pizza Hut.

For appointments, call 9840029856; for franchisee inquiries, contact P S Sriram at 8056000145.

Buttermilk distribution at Perungudi



Volunteering groups – Green Velachery and Vedhabharathi Organisation – is distributing buttermilk to the general public and conservancy workers in view of peak summer. The distribution happens at Seshadripuram Main Road near Pe-

rungudi railway station.

"Buttermilk is distributed to around 200 people since April 14. This will continue till May end. This is the fourth year of the distribution drive," says S. Kumararaja, a member of Green Velachery.

Walk to create awareness on multiple sclerosis

To commemorate World Multiple Sclerosis Day (May 30), a walk to create awareness about Multiple Sclerosis will be held on May 14 at Express Avenue between 5 p.m. and 7 p.m. "Walk In My Shoes" is the campaign slogan.

Multiple sclerosis (MS) is an autoimmune inflammatory demyelinating disease of the central nervous system. Multiple Sclerosis in India is an emerging neurological concern with an estimated 1.5 to 2 lakh people affected, said a release.

Called crippler of the young adult, it affects people in the age group of 14 to 40, more women than men. Due to low awareness overall, and general lack of knowledge, many patients often delay going to a neurologist. The delayed diagnosis leads to progression as it is a progressive disease, added the release.



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- * மனம் மகிழ்ச்சி அடைவதுடன் சிறப்பான வருமானம் பெறலாம்... மருத்துவ காப்பீடு வழங்குவதன் மூலம்...
- * சிறப்பாக செயல்பட்டு வரும் துறை
- * மக்களின் சேமிப்புகள், மருத்துவ செலவு மூலமாக கரையாமல் பாதுகாத்து வருமானமும் பெறலாம்...!!! மேலும் விவரம் மற்றும் செயல்பட...

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Free public speaking workshop

Speak Your Mind, in association with MUN Europe, is organising a free public speaking workshop on May 10, 2026, at Career Launcher, Alwarpet.

Open to students aged 6 to 21, the workshop is designed to help participants build confidence, improve clarity, and learn how to structure their ideas effectively based on their individual personality. Parents are also welcome to attend and watch their children perform.

This initiative aims to create a supportive environment where young speakers can develop essential communication skills that will benefit them academically and beyond.

Students can register online in advance, and spot registrations will also be available at the venue on the day of the event.

For more details and registration,

Contact: 9962194511

Planetarium closed tomorrow

B.M. Birla Planetarium of Tamil Nadu Science & Technology Centre on Gandhi Mandapam Road in Kotturpuram will remain closed on May 11 on account of the periodic general maintenance.

However, the permanent science exhibition, Science on a Sphere and 3D Science Theatre will function as usual, says a press release.

Workshops on beekeeping and soap making



Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre, Guindy, is conducting a workshop on beekeeping on May 14. Another workshop on making herbal soaps will be held on May 15.

According to a press release, participants will learn to make soaps from extracts of flowers, leaves, and fruits. Prior registration is necessary. The sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048.

Keeping them cool



Animals at Guindy Children's Park getting a water spray through sprinkler system set up as part of summer.

PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B

Workshop on fundamentals of EV technology

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is conducting a training programme on electrical vehicle technology from May 13 to 15 at its premises EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate in Ekkattuthangal. Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m.

According to a press release, the concepts covered in the workshop include: basics of power electronics, fundamentals of EV battery, regenerative braking, EV system architecture, electric motors used in EVs, battery management system, thermal management in EVs, EV powertrain operation, safety in EVs, EV performance parameters, basics of EV control systems, EV testing, efficiency and standards, EV applications and case studies, advantages, limitations and challenges of EVs.

For details, call 8668102600 / 8754495254

Bootcamp for CLAT 2027

Career Launcher, Chennai, is hosting a three-day CLAT 2027 Bootcamp from May 14-16, focusing on reading, reasoning, and test strategy. This will be held at its centre in Abiramapuram

A GK Quiz for CLAT aspirants will be held on May 17. Open to aspiring lawyers Call/WhatsApp 7550 330 159.

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